

Hackathon day — APS-04

Hyper-Personalized Recommendation Engine

Kognivera Hackathon 2026 · sprint **24–25 September 2026**, 12:00 to 12:00

This is the process for teams who have been selected. Read it a week before, not on the morning.

The shape of the three days

WHEN	WHAT HAPPENS
24 Sep, 12:00	Sprint starts. The clock is running.
24 Sep, 12:00 → 25 Sep, 12:00	24 hours of building. Mentors available; see below.
25 Sep, 12:00	Hard stop. Building ends and submission closes.
25 Sep, after 12:00	Lunch.
25 Sep, post-lunch	Presentations begin and run through the afternoon.
26 Sep	Finale — results announced and prizes awarded.

12:00 to 12:00 means exactly that. A commit at 12:01 is a commit after the sprint.

Before the day

One week out

- ☐ Every member can build and run the project from a clean checkout
- ☐ Accounts, API keys and quotas obtained and **tested** — not just requested
- ☐ The provided dataset loaded and queried by at least two people on the team
- ☐ `tools/validate_conformance.py` run once, and it passes
- ☐ You have decided who does what, and who owns the demo

The day before

- ☐ Repository created, everyone has push access, everyone has cloned it
 - ☐ Dependencies installed on every machine — do not plan to install over venue wi-fi
 - ☐ A hello-world deploy of your stack running end to end
 - ☐ Laptops, chargers, adapters, a power strip and a spare mouse
 - ☐ Sleep. Genuinely. The teams that demo badly are usually the ones that did not.
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Day one — 24 September

TIME	WHAT
<i>[TBC — reporting time]</i>	Arrive, check in, find your table.
<i>[TBC]</i>	Briefing: rules, mentor slots, submission mechanics, where everything is.
12:00	Sprint starts.
<i>[TBC]</i>	First mentor round.
<i>[TBC]</i>	Evening meal.
<i>[TBC]</i>	Overnight arrangements.

How to spend the first hour

Not writing code. Spend it agreeing three things: the single flow you will demo, who owns which piece, and what you will cut first if you fall behind. Teams that skip this hour lose four later.

Mentors

Mentors are there to unblock, review an approach and ask the awkward question. They will not write your code or debug your hardware. Come with a specific question — "our retrieval returns the wrong city, here is the query" gets a useful answer; "can you look at our project" does not.

Day two — 25 September

TIME	WHAT
<i>[TBC]</i>	Breakfast.
09:00	Three hours left. Stop building features.
09:00 → 11:00	Stabilise. Fix the demo path. Nothing new.
11:00 → 12:00	Rehearse the demo twice, on the machine you will demo from.
12:00	Hard stop. Submission closes.
After 12:00	Lunch.
Post-lunch	Presentations.

The 09:00 rule

At 09:00 on the second morning, stop adding features. Every hackathon has at least one team that had a working demo at 09:00, added one more thing, and had nothing at 12:00. The last three hours are for stabilising and rehearsing.

What you submit at 12:00

- Running application or demo covering your MVP scope
- Short solution write-up (use the Solution Submission Template)
- Final presentation (use the Final Presentation Template)

- Source code repository and a brief architecture note

[TBC — where the final submission is made, and whether the repository is submitted by link or archive]

Presentations — 25 September, post-lunch

Slot length	<i>[TBC] minutes presentation + [TBC] minutes questions</i>
Order	<i>[TBC — published on the morning of the 25th]</i>
Setup	<i>[TBC — whether you present from your own laptop or a shared machine]</i>

What a good presentation does

1. **Show the thing running.** In the first two minutes. A working build beats a polished deck, and nothing loses a room faster than four slides before the demo.
2. **Demo the one flow you rehearsed**, end to end, without apologising for what is missing.
3. **Show the AI feature actually working** — live, on real data, not a screenshot.
4. **Say what you cut and why.** Deliberate scope reads as judgement.
5. **Have the fallback ready.** A recorded run of your demo, on the machine, offline. Venue wi-fi has ended more demos than bad code.

Practicalities

- Test your display adapter before your slot, not during it
 - Have the app already running and warmed up before you are called
 - Close everything else on the machine
 - Decide who speaks. Two voices maximum
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Finale — 26 September

Results are announced and prizes are distributed. *[TBC — time and venue.]*

Rules

- Teams of 3–5. One problem statement per team.
- Building happens inside the 24 hours. Preparation — reading, learning the dataset, environment setup, a scaffold — is expected and encouraged before the sprint.
- Use any libraries, frameworks and AI tools you like. Say what you used.
- The provided dataset's mandatory core fields must not be renamed or re-keyed. Adding your own tables and columns beside them is encouraged.
- Everything must fit the Travel & Tourism theme and read as part of a coherent travel portal.
- Be decent to each other, to the mentors and to the venue.

What to bring

Laptop and charger · adapters for your display output · a power strip · headphones · a water bottle · anything you need to be comfortable for 24 hours

[TBC — venue address, entry arrangements, what is provided (meals, wi-fi, power), and the on-the-day contact number.]